

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 18

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: The narrator describes finishing her first marathon dead last, long after the crowds have gone.

1

At the thirty-second kilometre, my legs began to argue with me. They had been polite up to that point — uncomfortable, certainly, but reasonable. Now they spoke with the flat insistence of a person who has finally lost patience. **Stop**, they said. **We are done**. I did not stop. I kept up, instead, the slow shuffle that had passed for running these last forty minutes, and I told my legs, as one tells a tired child, that we would discuss it later.

2

Around me, the road had emptied. The fast runners had long since vanished into rumour. The middle of the field — that great cheerful river of bobbing caps and sweat — had thinned, then dispersed, and the few who remained ahead of me were so far down the long avenue that they appeared, in the late afternoon haze, to be walking. Behind me there was nothing. I was, by my own private calculation, last.

3

A volunteer at a water station gave me a small, tired smile as I passed, and then, with what she clearly believed was discretion, began to collapse the trestle table behind me. Further on, a man in a high-visibility vest was rolling up the bunting that had earlier marked off the route. The barriers were being lifted onto a flatbed truck. The marathon, for everyone except me, had finished some time ago. There is a peculiar humiliation in being the reason a finish line is still standing.

4

I considered, then, the question that every long-distance runner eventually considers, and that most learn to ignore. It was this: who exactly was I doing this for? There was no one waiting at the line with a banner. My family lived several hours away. The friends who had wished me luck that morning had assumed, quite reasonably, that I would have finished by now and were almost certainly eating dinner. The medal, when it came, would be handed to me by a teenager who had been told to stay one extra

hour. The honest answer, I realised, was **for myself**, and the honest answer was not, in that moment, particularly comforting.

5

It was somewhere around the forty-first kilometre that I became aware of footsteps beside me. An elderly man, perhaps seventy, in faded blue shorts and a plain white singlet, had drawn level with my left shoulder. He was not running with me, exactly; he was running **next to** me, at the same maddening shuffle, his thin arms swinging with the easy economy of someone who had done this many times. He did not look across. He did not speak. He simply held the pace, as though it were a small and obvious courtesy, and not the gift it actually was.

6

I did not ask him to stay. I was, by then, beyond polite conversation. But the unspoken arrangement between us — the steady fall of two pairs of feet on the empty road — did something to my breathing that I could not have done for myself. My ragged gasps began, slowly, to lengthen. The argument in my legs grew, for a few minutes, a little quieter. We passed the forty-second kilometre marker together. He did not glance at it. I did not either.

7

The finish line, when it arrived, was a sad little affair: a rope between two cones, a digital clock blinking apologetically, a single bored official with a clipboard. I crossed it at a pace barely faster than a brisk walk. The man beside me did not cross. He had peeled away, ten metres before the line, with a small nod that I caught only at the edge of my vision, and had jogged off down a side street as though he had merely been out for an evening trot. I never learned his name. I never had the chance to thank him.

8

The teenager pressed a medal into my hand. The clock read five hours and forty-three minutes. I sat down on the kerb and cried, briefly, with my face in my elbow, and then I laughed, which surprised me more than anything else that afternoon. I had not won. I had not been brave. I had simply refused, with a stubbornness I had not previously credited myself with, to stop. That, and the kindness of a stranger who asked nothing in return, was, I decided, enough.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says her legs “began to argue” with her and that she replied “as one tells a tired child”. Explain how this language helps us understand the narrator’s relationship with her own body at this point in the race. [2]

From Paragraph 2

2. Give **two** details from Paragraph 2 that show how far behind the other runners the narrator had fallen. [2]

From Paragraph 3

3. The narrator says there is “a peculiar humiliation in being the reason a finish line is still standing.” Explain, in your own words, why she feels humiliated. [2]

4. The volunteer’s smile is described as “small” and “tired”. What does this suggest about the situation at the water station? [1]

From Paragraph 4

5. The narrator says that the honest answer to her question “was not, in that moment, particularly comforting.”

(a) What is the honest answer she gives herself? [1]

(b) Why is this answer **not comforting** to her at this point in the race? [1]

From Paragraph 5

6. The narrator describes the elderly stranger as running “**next to** me” rather than “with me”. Why does the writer place the word **next to** in italics, and what does this emphasise? [2]

7. What impression do you form of the elderly stranger from Paragraph 5? Support your answer with **two** details from the paragraph. [3]

From Paragraph 6

8. Explain, in your own words, how the stranger’s presence helped the narrator, according to Paragraph 6. [2]

From Paragraph 7

9. The finish line is described as “a sad little affair”. Identify **one** detail from Paragraph 7 that supports this description. [1]

From Paragraph 8

10. The narrator says she finished with “a stubbornness I had not previously credited myself with”. What does this tell us about how she has come to see herself? [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]**Text 4: An opinion article on the hidden carbon cost of streaming media.****1**

A film, once watched, used to leave physical evidence behind: a rented disc to be returned, a videotape to be rewound, a cinema stub crumpled in a pocket. Streaming has abolished all of that. The film arrives, is consumed, and vanishes again into the cool indifference of “the cloud”. It feels, on the face of it, like the most weightless form of consumption ever invented. It is not. Every minute of streamed video is sustained by a vast, humming infrastructure of data centres, undersea cables and home routers, and that infrastructure runs, like everything else in the modern world, on electricity — much of it still drawn from fossil fuels.

2

The numbers are slippery, and have been the subject of an unusually noisy academic argument. Early estimates, widely reported in 2019, claimed that an hour of streamed video could emit as much carbon as driving a small car for four miles. Later analyses, undertaken with the cooperation of the industry, revised that figure sharply downwards — in some cases by a factor of forty. The true figure, most independent researchers now agree, lies somewhere in between, and depends heavily on the device used, the resolution selected, and, crucially, the carbon intensity of the local electricity grid. A film watched in Sweden, where the grid is largely hydroelectric, costs the atmosphere very little. The same film watched in Singapore or Indonesia, where natural gas and coal still dominate, costs considerably more.

3

What is **not** in dispute is that demand is growing. Global data-centre electricity consumption has roughly doubled in the last decade, and streaming video accounts for the lion’s share of internet traffic — by some estimates, more than sixty per cent. Two trends, in particular, are driving the increase. The first is the relentless climb in resolution: where standard definition once sufficed, viewers now expect High Definition, and increasingly Ultra-High Definition or “4K”, which uses up to four times more data than the previous standard. The second is the phenomenon of “background” streaming — a television playing in an empty room, a music service running quietly through the night, a child’s tablet left autoplaying episode after episode. Energy is consumed; nobody is watching.

4

Platforms, to their credit, have made the underlying technology far more efficient. Modern video codecs squeeze the same image into a fraction of the data they once required; the largest providers have moved aggressively to renewable energy for their own data centres; and some have begun, quietly, to default new users to lower resolutions unless a higher one is requested. These are genuine gains. The trouble is that they have been more than swallowed by the sheer growth in demand. Efficiency has improved by perhaps a factor of two over the last decade; total streaming hours have risen by a factor of ten. The carbon curve, in absolute terms, has not bent downwards. It has merely climbed less steeply than it might have done.

5

What, then, can be done? At the level of the individual viewer, the levers are modest but not trivial. Watching on a phone or laptop, rather than on a large television, can cut the energy cost of a film by a factor of five or more. Choosing standard definition over Ultra-High Definition, when the difference is barely perceptible on a smaller screen, can cut it by another. Pausing autoplay, downloading frequently watched content rather than re-streaming it, and avoiding the habit of streaming as ambient background noise — these are small, almost embarrassingly small, choices that, repeated across a billion households, would matter.

6

The heavier lifting, however, lies with companies and governments. Platforms could default to lower resolutions; they could disclose, on each title’s information page, an honest estimate of its carbon cost; they could redesign autoplay so that it stops, rather than continues, when a viewer’s attention has plainly wandered. Governments, for their part, could require that data centres be built only where the local grid is genuinely low-carbon, and could set efficiency standards for the chips and cooling systems on which those centres depend. None of this is technically difficult. What is missing is the political will and, behind that, the public pressure that creates it.

7

That pressure is slow to arrive, and the reason is partly that the cost is so well hidden. A flight emits visible vapour; a petrol engine produces an audible roar; even a beef burger arrives wrapped in a plain reminder of its origin. A streamed film offers none of these prompts. It costs nothing to start, requires no movement on the viewer’s part, and disappears the moment it ends. Until that invisibility is broken — until the carbon cost of a Friday-evening film is presented to viewers as plainly as its running time — most of us will continue to assume, comfortably and incorrectly, that we are doing nothing wrong.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says streaming feels like “the most weightless form of consumption ever invented.” What is the writer’s **attitude** towards this impression? [1]

13. Give **two** parts of the “infrastructure” mentioned in Paragraph 1 that allow streaming to take place. [2]

From Paragraph 2

14. Why does the writer describe the academic argument over streaming’s carbon cost as “unusually noisy”? Explain in your own words. [2]

15. According to Paragraph 2, why does the same film cost the atmosphere far less when watched in Sweden than in Singapore? [2]

From Paragraph 3

16. The writer puts the word **background** in inverted commas when describing a certain kind of streaming. Why? [2]

17. Using your own words as far as possible, explain the **two** trends identified in Paragraph 3 that are driving the increase in streaming’s energy demand. [2]

From Paragraph 4

18. The writer says of platforms’ efficiency gains: “These are genuine gains. The trouble is that they have been more than swallowed by the sheer growth in demand.” Explain, in your own words, what the writer means by **swallowed** in this sentence. [2]

From Paragraph 5

19. The writer describes the changes a viewer can make as “small, almost embarrassingly small, choices”. Why does the writer add the phrase **almost embarrassingly small**, and what does it suggest about his view of individual action? [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer claims that “none of this is technically difficult.” Justify, in your own words, why he is confident that the changes he proposes are achievable. [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. In Paragraph 7, the writer contrasts streaming with a flight, a petrol engine and a beef burger. What is the **purpose** of this contrast? [2]

22. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

23. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **why streaming media has a significant and growing carbon cost**, and **what can be done by individuals and by companies or governments to reduce it**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Streaming carries a significant carbon cost because ...

— END OF PAPER —